THE IAF'S TRANSPORT FLEET

DORNIER 228

INDUCTED IN: 1986
STRENGTH: 50

↘ Payload of 2.3 tonnes; 19-25 troops

ILYUSHIN IL-76

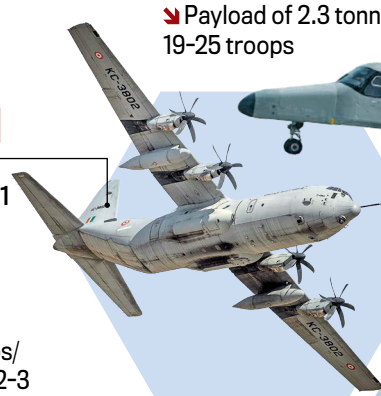
INDUCTED IN: 1985; **STRENGTH:** 17

↘ Russian-made 'workhorse of the skies'. Can transport 60 tonnes cargo, including men, equipment, vehicles

C130-J SUPER HERCULES*

INDUCTED IN: 2011
STRENGTH: 12

↘ Made by US' Lockheed Martin, it has a 20 tonne capacity: 92 troops/ 64 paratroopers/ 2-3 armoured carriers



ANTONOV AN-32/ AN-32 RE

INDUCTED IN: 1984;
STRENGTH: 104

↘ Tactical light transport aircraft made by Antonov Design Bureau of Ukraine, capable of carrying 7.5 tonnes of cargo/ 50 troops





C-295*

INDUCTED IN: 2023

STRENGTH: Currently one, 15 more to arrive from Spain; 40 to be made jointly by Airbus and Tata

↘ The Airbus C-295 can carry 9.2 tonnes; up to 71 troops along with equipment

*Capable of night ops

HS 748 HAWKER SIDDELEY (AVRO)

INDUCTED IN: 1964
STRENGTH: 57

↘ UK-made aircraft with carrying capacity of 5.1 tonnes; 40-58 troops



C-17 GLOBEMASTER III*

INDUCTED IN: 2013;
STRENGTH: 11

↘ Made by Boeing, it has a capacity of up to 77 tonnes: 102 paratroopers/ 134 troops

goggles (NVGs) and infrared thermal imagery—was employed during evacuation missions, including at night, from conflict-hit Afghanistan.

Since acquiring the Super Hercules, the IAF has pushed it towards its optimum capability through a graded approach. After being used in airfields across India, they were used for operations in the high-altitude airfields in Leh, Thoise and Daulat Beg Oldie. Finally, they began landing at night at these places. Not just the C-130J, the IAF's other transport jets, too, have completed numerous sorties at Leh and Thoise to meet the army's needs at forward posts.

A senior IAF officer claims that though the C-130J was inducted over a decade ago, the pilot night vision capability was added later. The IAF says that with NVGs, pilots don't need a moonlit night—the usual practice earlier—to secure a failsafe night landing. NVGs are a gamechanger as far as dangerous night landings are concerned, allowing pilots to land even in total darkness. Though the IAF inducted NVGs in 2022, the Super Hercules is the only aircraft to use them regularly. Now, the IAF is providing NVG training to C-17 Globemaster pilots; the C-295s will also have them. The IAF's fleet of helicopters, including the Chinooks, are NVG-compliant.

SHOW OF INTENT

Air Vice Marshal Manmohan Bahadur (retd) says that the Kargil night landing was a capability demonstration with long-term implications. It showed that the IAF is opening up areas for quick induction of troops and logistics. When the Nyoma airfield in Ladakh is fully operational, it will give an exponential boost to the logistics support capability of the IAF, he says. "These are vital requirements, considering the belligerent attitude of China in the Ladakh area," Bahadur tells INDIA TODAY.

Another air marshal says that no air force except the IAF lands aircraft regularly on such high-altitude airfields as Kargil. China does have high-altitude bases in Tibet, but usually relies on its extensive road/ rail network for moving men and materiel. In contrast, IAF planes land daily on airfields in Eastern Ladakh, like Thoise and Leh, most of which are above 10,000 ft. "By landing at such difficult places, it sends a message to the enemy that a battalion can be brought from anywhere in a matter of hours. Besides, it demonstrates the ability to resupply forces and evacuate casualties, even at night," says another key IAF officer.

The IAF's transport wing can take inspiration from its forebear. On October 25, 1962, soon after the start of the Indo-China War, the IAF airlifted 20 AMX-13 tanks to Chushul, in Ladakh, in a Russian-made An-12 aircraft. The first batch of tanks was loaded on to the aircraft in Chandigarh on the night of October 24–25; the second batch was loaded the following night and arrived in Chushul on October 26. The tanks stalled the Chinese advancement in the sector. The current fleet has that achievement to live up to. ■